

Daily Brief — Wednesday, August 26, 2026

Ground News Cross-Spectrum Analysis

Portfolio Snapshot (latest CSV: Jul 31, 2026 7:54 AM ET)

Key Holdings: MU, HUT, STX, INTC, RIOT, CORZ, BE, AAPL, XOP, SHEL, VDE, AMD, AMZN, GOOGL, NFLX, CEG, TSLA, APLD, V, DIS, WMT, etc.

Market Overview

Convergent facts:

- AP News (Aug 25): S&P 500 rose 0.3% Tuesday, edging closer to all-time high. Oil prices fell, which helped ease bond market worries and support stocks.
- AP News (Aug 24): U.S. stocks drifted to a mixed finish; S&P 500 slipped 0.3% Monday, Nasdaq added 0.2%, Dow fell 0.4%.
- AP News (Aug 26, 2025 reference): Stocks closed higher after an afternoon push left major indexes just below recent records.
- Reuters: U.S. Treasury yields and dollar fell as Trump renewed pressure on the Fed; U.S. stocks rose.
- NY Post (Aug 20): Dow plunged 600-700 points on surging Treasury yields and Walmart sales shock.
- CNN (Aug 4): S&P 500 back at record high; Dow hit 54,000.

Where they differ:

- Left (CNN): Emphasizes Trump vs. Fed conflict, political pressure on Fed independence, and headline market records. Framing: "Trump is losing his fight with the Fed."
- Center (AP/Reuters): Facts-first reporting on index moves, oil prices, bond yields, and earnings calendar. Neutral on causality.
- Right (NY Post/Fox): Emphasizes market volatility, inflation worries, and sharp drops. Headlines often more alarmist on Treasury yields and Fed policy.

Likely Reality:

Market is in a choppy, earnings-driven rally near record highs. Falling oil is reducing bond-yield pressure, which is supportive for equities. Fed independence concerns are real but contained by courts/institutions for now. Direction is cautiously higher but headline-sensitive.

Key Stories

1. Nvidia Earnings — AI Trade Bellwether

Sources: CNN (Left) | Reuters (Center) | Fox News (Right)

WHERE THEY AGREE:

- Nvidia reports earnings this week; results expected to significantly impact broader market.
- AI demand remains strong.
- China chip sales uncertainty is a major overhang.

WHERE THEY DIFFER:

- Left (CNN): "Nvidia says it's missing out on China sales as it awaits guidelines on US 15% pay-to-play plan." Frames as

Trump policy uncertainty hurting a US tech champion.

- Center (Reuters): "Nvidia still growing, but China uncertainty clouds outlook." Notes Nvidia forecasts Q3 revenue above estimates, but assumes no H20 chip sales to China.
- Right (Fox): "NVIDIA is the benchmark for AI builds, strategist says." Focuses on Nvidia's centrality to AI infrastructure and investment narrative.

Blindspots:

- Left sources omit: Nvidia's revenue beat and strong Q3 guidance.
- Right sources omit: Regulatory/political risk to China revenue stream.
- Center sources cover: Both growth and China risk, but less narrative on political blame.

Likely Reality:

Nvidia's core AI business is still strong, but China exposure adds volatility. The stock will likely move on guidance clarity, not just Q2 results. Net neutral-to-bullish if guidance holds; bearish if China risk escalates.

2. Federal Reserve & Trump Pressure

Sources: CNN (Left) | Reuters (Center) | Fox News (Right)

WHERE THEY AGREE:

- Fed Chair Kevin Warsh is now at the helm; Jackson Hole speech this week is closely watched.
- The White House has attempted to remove Fed Governor Lisa Cook.
- Supreme Court rejected Trump's bid to fire Cook while expanding some presidential powers (per Reuters, June 29).

WHERE THEY DIFFER:

- Left (CNN): "Trump is losing his fight with the Fed." Frames as institutional resistance to political interference. "Warsh promises a new vision for the Fed, as his colleagues eye a rate hike instead of a cut."
- Center (Reuters): Reports court decisions and policy uncertainty factually. State Street: "Fed likely to stay on hold through year-end."
- Right (Fox): "Kevin Warsh on Fed's policy: 'Surprise is not the objective function.'" Emphasizes Fed stability and predictability under new leadership.

Blindspots:

- Left sources omit: Market has been resilient despite Fed conflict; yields have fallen.
- Right sources omit: Ongoing institutional/legal risk from White House pressure.
- Center sources cover: The actual policy outlook (pause/hold) rather than political drama.

Likely Reality:

The Fed remains under political pressure, but markets have priced in institutional resilience. The most likely near-term path is a pause/hold, not aggressive cuts or hikes. Jackson Hole could reset expectations if Warsh signals a new framework.

3. China Tariffs / Trade War

Sources: CNN (Left) | Reuters (Center) | NY Post/Fox (Right)

WHERE THEY AGREE:

- U.S. is planning new tariffs on Chinese goods, around 7.5%, before a potential Xi-Trump summit.
- EU trade measures could impact up to 27% of China's exports, per Goldman Sachs.
- Trump is not considering pausing tariffs despite global turmoil.

WHERE THEY DIFFER:

- Left (CNN): "Tariffs raised prices you paid. But most businesses won't be passing tariffs refunds back to you." Focus on consumer cost.
- Center (Reuters/AP/Bloomberg): Reports the 7.5% figure and summit context factually.
- Right (NY Post/Fox): Frames tariff escalation as tough-on-China policy; less focus on consumer impact.

Blindspots:

- Left sources omit: Summit diplomacy possibility and targeted nature (overcapacity).
- Right sources omit: Downside risk to corporate margins and consumer prices.
- Center sources cover: Specific numbers and timeline.

Likely Reality:

Tariffs are likely to persist and expand modestly, but a summit could moderate worst-case scenarios. Corporate supply chains and consumers will absorb costs; market impact is mixed—bad for multinationals with China exposure, less bad for domestically focused firms.

4. Oil & Energy Markets

Sources: CNN (Left) | Reuters (Center) | Fox/NY Post (Right)

WHERE THEY AGREE:

- Oil has dropped recently despite new U.S. sanctions on Iran.
- Six months into the Iran war, almost half of global oil flows are from war zones.
- Oil companies are making large profits, creating political tension.
- EU countries are discussing windfall-profit taxes on oil companies.

WHERE THEY DIFFER:

- Left (CNN): "Red lights are flashing in energy markets." Warns about geopolitical risk and corporate profiteering.
- Center (Reuters): "Oil drops more than \$2 despite new US sanctions on Iran." Focuses on market reaction and supply/demand balance.
- Right (Fox/NY Post): Less prominent coverage; when covered, emphasizes market volatility and Biden/Trump policy effects.

Blindspots:

- Left sources omit: Falling oil is actually helping stocks by lowering yields and inflation fears.
- Right sources omit: Long-term geopolitical supply risk from Iran war.
- Center sources cover: Both price moves and war-zone supply risk.

Likely Reality:

Oil is caught between near-term demand weakness/falling prices and longer-term geopolitical supply risk. Energy stocks are mixed: integrated oils (XOM, CVX, SHEL) benefit from profits but face political/windfall-tax risk; explorers (XOP, VDE) are more volatile with crude prices.

5. Bitcoin & Crypto Rally

Sources: CNN (Left) | Reuters (Center) | Fox (Right)

WHERE THEY AGREE:

- Bitcoin rose above \$80,000 this week.
- Crypto shares climbed after Treasury buybacks/Clarity Act developments.

- Washington policy is a key driver of the rally.

WHERE THEY DIFFER:

- Left (CNN): "Crypto is booming. Washington is driving the rally." Notes Trump crypto meeting and political angle.
- Center (Reuters): "Bitcoin rises above \$80,000 as soft dollar, debasement fears boost momentum." Focuses on macro drivers (dollar weakness, debasement fears).
- Right (Fox): Less direct crypto coverage in top results; generally supportive of deregulation narrative.

Blindspots:

- Left sources omit: Macro/USD debasement narrative.
- Right sources omit: Specific policy catalysts and Trump involvement.
- Center sources cover: Price action and macro rationale.

Likely Reality:

Crypto rally is being driven by both political/regulatory optimism (Washington) and macro fears (soft dollar, debasement). For Thad's holdings (HUT, RIOT, CORZ, COIN, FBTC, APLD, WULF, CLSK, CIFR), this is broadly supportive but highly volatile.

Portfolio News & Impact

MU — Micron Technology

News: Micron unveils \$10 billion AI memory research lab in Boise (Reuters, Aug 20). Earlier reported 346% sales jump driven by AI demand (CNN, Jun 25).

Spectrum: Left highlights AI sales surge; Center reports the Boise investment and China chip-tool lobbying.

Blindspot: Right largely not covering Micron's AI momentum.

Market Implication: Bullish. AI memory demand is a real tailwind; Boise lab signals long-term commitment. China competition risk remains.

INTC — Intel

News: U.S. to take 10% equity stake in Intel as part of Trump tech push (Reuters/CNN, Aug 22, 2025). Recent headlines show government still working on deal details.

Spectrum: Left frames as Trump's "big tech push"; Center reports factual deal mechanics; Right supportive of reshoring/national security angle.

Blindspot: Center notes government says deal still being worked on—details matter.

Market Implication: Neutral-to-bullish. Government stake is a backstop, but Intel turnaround remains uncertain. Watch for actual capital injection terms.

BE — Bloom Energy

News: No major recent headlines. Last notable: carbon-capture partnership with Chart Industries (Reuters, Feb 2025).

Spectrum: Only Reuters/company pages have coverage; limited political angle.

Blindspot: Left/Right not discussing Bloom recently.

Market Implication: Neutral. No news is no news; stock remains a hydrogen/fuel-cell speculation play.

CORZ — Core Scientific

News: Shareholders rejected \$9 billion CoreWeave offer; deal terminated (Reuters, Oct 2025). Stock has been volatile on AI data-center pivot narrative.

Spectrum: Center reports deal collapse factually; Left/Right minimal.

Blindspot: Limited coverage of what's next for CORZ as a standalone miner/AI infrastructure play.

Market Implication: Neutral. Deal overhang removed, but standalone path is uncertain and tied to crypto/AI demand.

APLD — Applied Digital

News: Signed \$5.2 billion AI data-center lease with U.S. hyperscaler (Reuters, Jun 2026) and earlier \$7.5 billion lease (Apr 2026). Quarterly net loss widened on rising costs (Apr 2026).

Spectrum: Center covers the big lease wins and losses; Left/Right largely absent.

Blindspot: Sustainability of lease economics and path to profitability not widely discussed.

Market Implication: Bullish on revenue visibility, but risky due to losses and execution. Data-center AI demand is the catalyst.

STX — Seagate

News: Data storage firms Western Digital, Seagate soared on AI-driven demand spike (Reuters, Oct 2025). Seagate forecasts robust Q4 on steady demand for mass-capacity storage (Apr 2025).

Spectrum: Center covers AI storage demand; Left/Right not prominent.

Blindspot: Valuation and cyclical risk under-discussed.

Market Implication: Bullish. AI data storage is a durable demand tailwind.

CEG — Constellation Energy

News: Three Mile Island restart delayed until 2031 due to transmission issues (Reuters, Mar/Apr 2026). Secured 20-year license extensions for two nuclear plants (Dec 2025). Reached DOJ agreement for Calpine acquisition (Dec 2025).

Spectrum: Center reports operational/regulatory updates; Left covers climate/nuclear angle sparingly; Right supportive of energy security.

Blindspot: Three Mile Island delay is a real negative that may be underweighted in bullish nuclear/AI power narratives.

Market Implication: Neutral-to-bearish short term on the delay, but bullish long term on nuclear/AI power demand.

XOP / VDE / Energy ETFs and SHEL / XOM / CVX

News: Exxon made \$160 million per day last quarter as oil prices surged (CNN, Jul 31). Shell's South Africa exploration blocked by top court (Reuters, Aug 14). Oil profits are a political headache for Trump (CNN, Aug 4).

Spectrum: Left highlights windfall profits and political backlash; Center reports earnings and legal/operational facts; Right less prominent.

Blindspot: Left may underplay current oil-price decline; Right may underplay windfall-tax risk.

Market Implication: Mixed. Near-term oil weakness hurts, but big oil profits and capital returns support. Political risk is rising.

TSLA — Tesla

News: CNN (Jul 22): "Will SpaceX buy Tesla? Musk is not revealing his plans." Tesla touts California robotaxis but hasn't sought permits (Reuters, Feb 2026). Trump threatens 50% tariffs on Canadian cars/trucks (Reuters, Aug 24).

Spectrum: Left focuses on Musk/SpaceX speculation and governance; Center covers operational/regulatory facts; Right covers tariffs/trade.

Blindspot: Actual delivery/earnings trajectory is getting lost in Musk headlines.

Market Implication: Neutral-to-bearish. Stock is down 30% from cost basis. Headline risk around Musk, robotaxis, and tariffs. Needs fundamental reset.

AMZN / GOOGL / AAPL / NFLX / DIS / WMT / HD / CART

News: Apple paid 40% of global taxes to Ireland (Reuters, Aug 21). Apple Mac users in China can connect to Alibaba's Qwen AI (Reuters, Aug 8). iPhone 17 easing AI concerns (CNN, Jan 2026). Walmart/HD/CART consumer stocks weaker recently.

Spectrum: Left covers consumer impact and Apple AI; Center reports tax/China facts.

Blindspot: Right under-covers big-tech antitrust/tax risks.

Market Implication: Mixed. Megacap tech (AMZN, GOOGL, AAPL) fairly resilient; consumer discretionary (WMT, HD, CART) showing weakness.

Blindspot Report

1. Dollar weakness / debasement narrative: Center/Reuters is covering it; Left and Right are underweighting the macro driver behind gold, silver, and crypto moves. Relevant to PSLV, SGOL, GLDM, PHYS, FBTC, FETH.
 2. Three Mile Island delay: Potentially under-reported vs. bullish nuclear/AI power narrative. CEG holders should watch.
 3. Falling oil as equity tailwind: Left focuses on geopolitical risk; market reality is lower oil = lower yields = higher stocks.
 4. Trump-Fed institutional conflict: Both sides cover, but the market's ability to shrug it off may be a blindspot for everyone.
 5. Small-cap/speculative AI infrastructure: APLD, CORZ, BE, HTFL, TEM, RXRX get limited cross-spectrum coverage; price action may be driven by sentiment/flow more than fundamentals.
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Pre-Market Outlook

Bullish factors:

- Indexes near record highs; AI demand resilient (Nvidia, Micron, Seagate).
- Bitcoin above \$80,000 supports crypto holdings.
- Falling oil eases bond-yield/inflation fears.
- Government backstop for Intel.

Bearish factors:

- Trump-Fed conflict unresolved; Jackson Hole could surprise.
- China tariff escalation and summit uncertainty.
- Oil geopolitical supply risk (Iran war).
- Tesla and some consumer names under pressure.
- Portfolio has significant exposure to volatile crypto/AI infrastructure names.

Overall Call: Cautiously Bullish / Neutral.

Convergent facts point to a resilient market with AI and crypto as leadership themes. The biggest near-term risks are Fed/trade surprises and oil volatility. Thad's portfolio is tilted toward high-beta tech, crypto, and energy—well-positioned if the rally continues, but vulnerable to a risk-off swing.

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